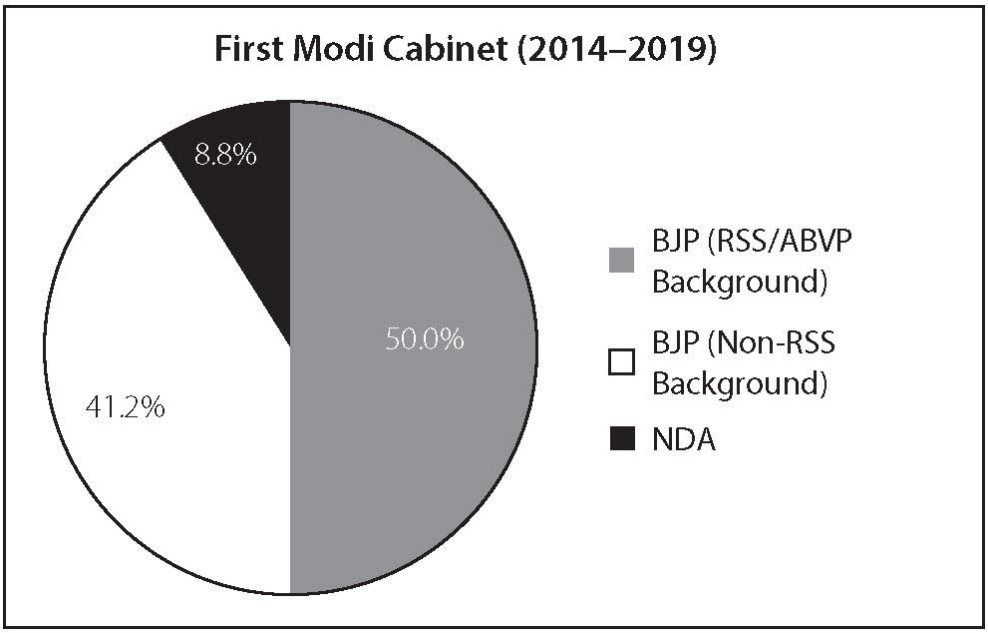
because they have links with the RSS is not a fair comment'.[52] An RSS functionary also stressed that the organisation has 'no role in deciding tickets for the party or deciding the portfolio. Yet, at the same time, RSS only believes in two things—there are those who are already with us and those who are yet to come under the fold.'[53]

Figure 12.5 Ministers with RSS Background Accounted for 50 per cent of Modi's First Cabinet (2014–2019)



Source: Author's fieldwork, with research support from Rajiv Pundir. Note: Breakdown based on Union cabinet list as of 13 November 2018. It does not include erstwhile ministers with an RSS background, like Venkaiah Naidu, who in 2017 was appointed vice president, or Ananth Kumar, who passed away on 12 November 2018.[51]

The RSS's influence on the BJP and its ideas becomes even clearer when we examine the backgrounds of the party's office-bearers at the national level. Specifically, we looked at sixty-one leaders (fifty-seven national office-bearers and four members of the Margdarshak Mandal). Here, the number of those with an RSS background came to 45.9 per cent (see Figure 12.7). Among them were J.P. Nadda, who like Amit Shah had started his political career with the RSS, and B.L. Santhosh, party general secretary, who was on loan to the BJP from the RSS. The actual influence of those with